

Design and Deployment of an Imaging Spectrometer for the Characterisation of Spatial Chirp



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Contents

1	Introduction	1
1.1	Plasma Modulated Plasma Accelerator	1
1.2	Angular and Spatial Chirp	2
1.2.1	Chirped Pulse Amplification	2
1.2.2	Angular-to-Spatial Chirp Conversion at Focus	3
1.2.3	Consequences for P-MoPA	4
1.3	Measuring Spatial Chirp	6
1.4	Project Objectives	6
1.5	Report Outline	7
2	Optical Design	8
2.1	Optical Layout	8
2.2	Camera and Acquisition Hardware	10
2.3	Alignment Procedure	10
2.3.1	Grating-Camera Axis Alignment	10
2.3.2	Slit-Camera Axis Alignment	10
3	Calibration	11
3.1	Calibration Architecture	11
3.2	Sensor Calibration	11
3.2.1	Baseline	11
3.2.2	Flat Field	11
3.2.3	Bad Pixel Map	11
3.2.4	Conversion Gain	11
3.3	Spatial Calibration	11
3.4	Spectral Calibration	11
3.4.1	Grating Geometry and Predicted Line Spacing	11
3.4.2	Line Matching	11

3.4.3	Wavelength Fit and Non-Linear Dispersion	11
4	Analysis Pipeline	12
4.1	Preprocessing Pipeline	12
4.2	Noise Model and Uncertainty Propagation	12
4.3	Spatial Dispersion Fitting	12
4.3.1	Optical Design Trade-off: Focal-Length Selection	12
4.4	Multi-Shot Combination	12
5	Graphical User Interface	13
5.1	Why a GUI	13
5.2	A Typical Workflow Session	13
6	Experimental Design	14
6.1	Testing with a Known, Controllable Chirp Source	14
6.2	Glass-Induced Spatial Chirp	14
6.3	Predicted Spatial Dispersion	14
6.4	Physical Setup	14
6.5	Measurement Procedure	14
7	Results	15
7.1	No Glass Window Baseline	15
7.2	One Glass Window	15
7.3	Two Glass Windows	15
7.4	Three Glass Windows	15
7.5	Summary of Discrepancies	15
8	Discussion	16
8.1	Taxonomy of Potential Systematic Errors	16
8.2	Data-Analysis Systematics Considered	16
8.3	Physical Systematics Considered	16
8.3.1	Chromatic Aberration and $M(\lambda)$	16
8.3.2	Residual Camera-Grating Tilt	16
8.3.3	Scheimpflug-Type Tilt	16
8.3.4	Other Misalignments and Defects	16
8.4	Assessment	16

9	Conclusions and Future Work	17
9.1	Conclusions	17
9.2	Future Work	17
	References	18

List of Figures

1.1	The Plasma Modulated Plasma Accelerator (P-MoPA) scheme.	2
1.2	Illustration of Chirped Pulse Amplification (CPA).	3
1.3	Spatially chirped lens and axicon foci.	4
1.4	Spatially and un-spatially chirped imaging spectrometer-camera images.	6
2.1	Imaging spectrometer schematic.	9
2.2	Photograph of the imaging spectrometer.	9

Chapter 1

Introduction

1.1 Plasma Modulated Plasma Accelerator

A plasma can be formed by ionising a gas target using a high-intensity, short (10 fs) laser pulse. The interaction of the laser pulse with the plasma can form accelerating structures with field strengths of the order of 100 GV/m. In a laser-wakefield accelerator scheme (LWFA), these accelerating structures may be used to achieve electron energies in the order of 100s MeV to GeV [1]. Such schemes may lead to the production of compact, low cost electron sources with applications such as light source generation [2], QED experiments [3], radiobiology studies [4], and probing fundamental plasma physics [5].

LWFA schemes are currently limited by the repetition rates of their laser systems, most commonly $\lesssim 10$ Hz with Ti:sapphire lasers. The University of Oxford's Laser Plasma Accelerator Group (LPAG) is working with collaborators on the plasma-modulated plasma accelerator (P-MoPA) project to address this [6, 7, 8, 9, 10]. The project aims to use thin-disk lasers with high repetition rates (~ 1 kHz) to drive a LWFA electron source. The pulse duration of such lasers is too long to drive a LWFA, so the following scheme is used to create a pulse-train (see Figure 1.1): A short, low-energy seed-pulse is co-propagated with a long drive-pulse through a modulator stage containing a gas. The seed-pulse ionises the gas and drives a low-intensity plasma wave that modulates the drive-pulse, producing side-bands in its spectrum. A compressor then removes the phase on these side-bands, converting the picosecond pulse into a train of short pulses spaced temporally by the plasma period. This pulse train can then be directed into a second plasma stage of the same density, resonantly exciting a wakefield into which electrons can be injected and subsequently accelerated. This modulation-compression process is sensitive to the drive-pulse's spatio-spectral content; any spatio-spectral couplings would vary the modulation across the pulse's

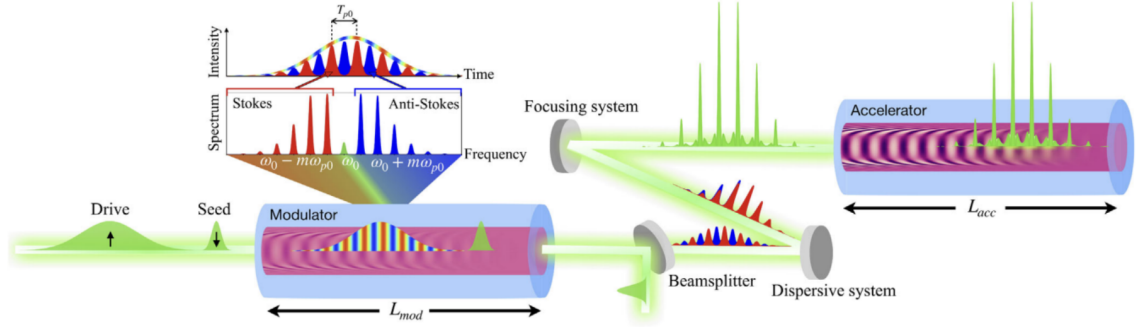


Figure 1.1: The Plasma Modulated Plasma Accelerator (P-MoPA) scheme. Reproduced from [6].

profile and degrade the resulting pulse-train, weakening the pulse-train’s ability to drive a wakefield and leading to unstable electron acceleration. The characterisation of spatio-spectral couplings in the thin-disk lasers used in the P-MoPA project is thus essential for the project’s success.

1.2 Angular and Spatial Chirp

1.2.1 Chirped Pulse Amplification

Prior to Gérard Mourou and Donna Strickland’s invention of chirped pulse amplification (CPA) [11], for which they were awarded the Nobel Prize in Physics in 2018, it was extremely challenging to produce ultrashort laser pulses with enough intensity for modern LWFA without damaging the optical equipment and introducing non-linear effects. CPA avoids these issues through a staged amplification procedure (see Figure 1.2): An ultrashort, low-amplitude pulse enters a pulse stretcher, composed of two identical parallel diffraction gratings. This stretches the pulse temporally, reducing its intensity without loss of energy. The pulse is subsequently amplified then directed through a pulse compressor, similar to the pulse stretcher, which compresses the pulse back to its original duration. The result is a high-intensity ultrashort pulse, but crucially this intensity is only reached post-compressor, leaving all previous optical components unharmed.

As with most real optical systems, CPA systems are highly sensitive to misalignments. In particular, a relative misalignment between the two gratings of the stretcher or the compressor, or a mismatch between the dispersive properties of the stretcher and the compressor, may produce spatio-spectral couplings in the pulse. One such coupling is known as *angular chirp*, a correlation between the angle of propagation

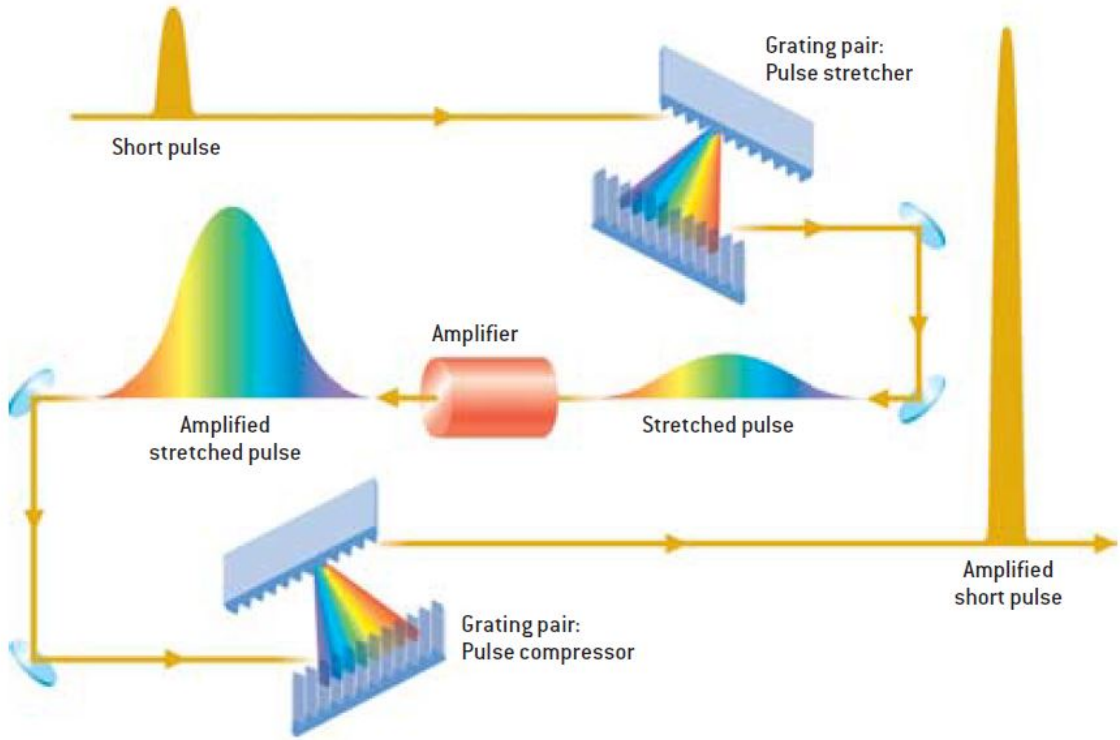


Figure 1.2: Illustration of Chirped Pulse Amplification (CPA). Reproduced from [12].

θ and wavelength λ within a pulse of finite bandwidth. When an angularly chirped pulse propagates over a finite distance, it acquires *spatial chirp*, a correlation between position x along an arbitrary transverse axis across a pulse and wavelength λ .

1.2.2 Angular-to-Spatial Chirp Conversion at Focus

A useful property of the converging lens is the conversion between angular and spatial information at its focal plane. In particular, any collimated plane wave incident on an ideal thin lens of focal length f is, in the paraxial approximation, focussed to a transverse position x on the lens' back focal plane proportional to its angle of incidence θ :

$$x = f\theta. \quad (1.1)$$

Consequently, if the incident pulse is angularly chirped, meaning θ is spectrally dependent, the transverse position x of the resulting focal spot also becomes spectrally dependent, meaning it is spatially chirped. The result is a focal spot that is stretched along an arbitrary transverse axis, as opposed to a typical circular focal spot. (see Figure 1.3).

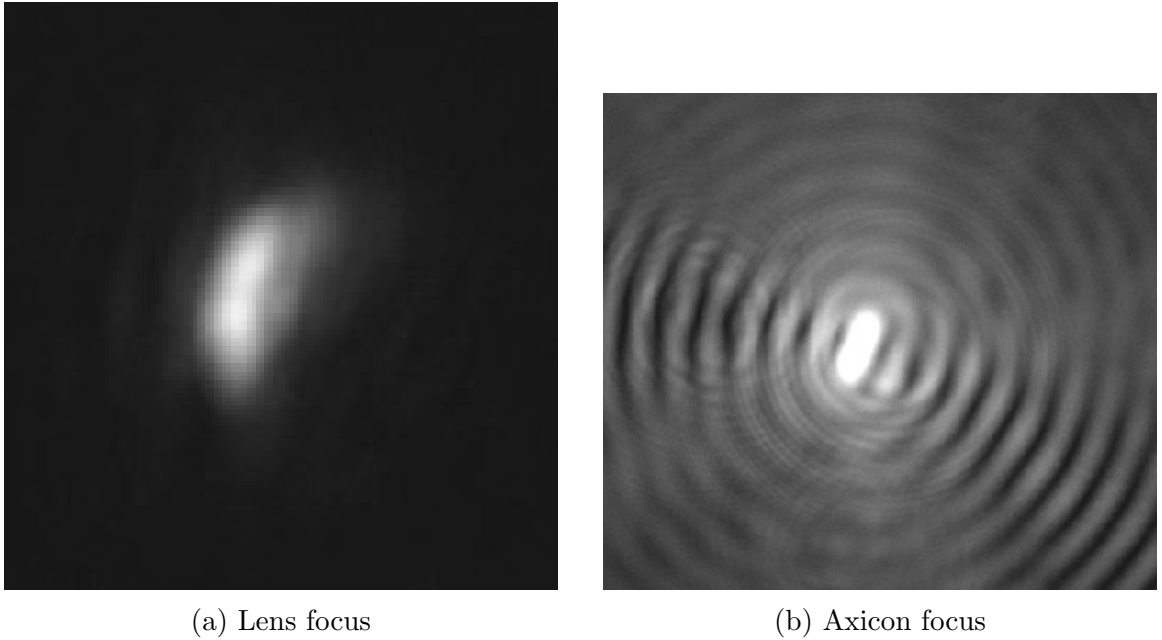


Figure 1.3: Spatially chirped foci resulting from angularly chirped incident pulses. Images courtesy of Alexander Harrison.

Differentiating Equation 1.1 with respect to wavelength λ :

$$\frac{dx}{d\lambda} = f \frac{d\theta}{d\lambda}. \quad (1.2)$$

The derivative $\zeta \equiv \frac{dx}{d\lambda}$ is known as *spatial dispersion*, corresponding to a pulse’s spectrally dependent transverse position $x(\lambda)$, and is the conventional metric used for describing spatial chirp throughout this project. Another common metric used for describing spatial chirp is known as the frequency gradient, $\frac{d\omega}{dx}$, corresponding to a pulse’s transverse-positionally dependent angular frequency $\omega(x)$. While these parameterisations both describe spatial chirp, they are not simply reciprocals of each other [13]. Spatial dispersion is used throughout this project because of its convenient relationship with the angular dispersion $\frac{d\theta}{d\lambda}$ that produces it. Wavelength is chosen as the spectral unit throughout this project due to its direct relationship with the diffraction angle of optical gratings.

1.2.3 Consequences for P-MoPA

A spatially chirped focal spot occupies a larger area than otherwise, reducing the focus’ peak intensity. Furthermore, the spatial separation of optical frequencies at the focus means the local bandwidth is reduced, which can lengthen the pulse’s duration and also resulting in a reduced peak intensity. For a channel-forming pulse used to

ionise a plasma channel for the P-MoPA accelerator stage, a sufficient reduction in peak intensity may lead to incomplete ionisation or a lower ionisation state, modifying the electron-density profile of the plasma formed [14]. If this changes the effective plasma density experienced by the pulse train, then this is particularly detrimental to the P-MoPA scheme because the modulation and acceleration plasma stages must share the same plasma frequency. This is precisely what allows the pulse train to have the appropriate spacing required to resonantly drive a wakefield in the accelerator stage [8]. Additionally, the initially ionised plasma column may have a smaller radius, as the radial distance at which the pulse's transverse intensity distribution crosses the ionisation threshold moves inward. At sufficiently low intensity, the volume of gas ionised and the energy deposited into the plasma may become insufficient to form a guiding channel with the desired properties [14].

The wakefield is driven by the ponderomotive force associated with the pulse train, which is proportional to the gradient of the laser intensity [1, 6]. If the pulse train is focussed to a spatially chirped focal spot at the entrance to the accelerator stage's plasma channel, each pulse's peak intensity is reduced and its intensity distribution broadened, generally reducing the intensity gradients, leading to a wakefield with reduced field strength. Electrons are therefore accelerated to lower energies, reducing the utility of the project for its various applications [9]. Furthermore, if a pulse's frequency components enter the plasma channel at varying transverse positions and angles due to spatial and angular chirp, they may not all couple equally into the desired guiding mode, reduced the fraction of energy coupled into this mode. Higher order modes may also be excited, causing asymmetric transverse field distributions, and producing interference that oscillates the intensity distribution longitudinally down the plasma channel [9, 15].

Aside from spatial chirp at the focus, angular chirp is also closely associated with pulse-front tilt, where different transverse positions reach peak intensity at different times [16]. This spatio-temporal coupling leads to a transversely asymmetric drive of the plasma wave, producing an asymmetric wakefield that may deflect accelerated electrons from the optical axis [17]. While this effect may be used to steer the accelerated electron beam, it is not always desirable, and the ability to control it is essential.

Within the modulator, angular chirp may also reduce the coupling of the seed and drive pulses to the plasma channel's guided mode as well as modifying their spatial overlap with each other, distorting the modulation of the drive pulse. These

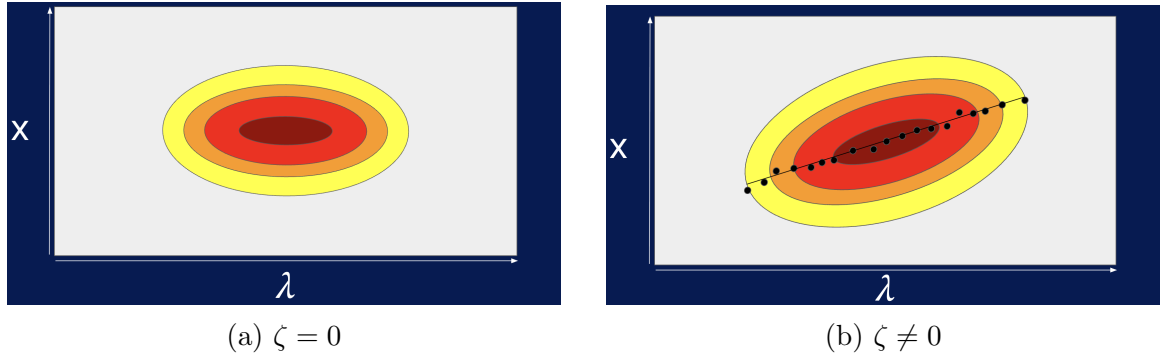


Figure 1.4: Illustration of imaging spectrometer-camera images of an un-spatially chirped pulse (a) and a spatially chirped pulse with plotted $x_0(\lambda)$ and a line of best fit (b).

distortions may affect the pulse train and can cause further issues in the accelerator stage.

1.3 Measuring Spatial Chirp

One must be able to detect the existence of spatio-spectral couplings in a laser system before being able to correct them. A common device used for such detection is called an imaging spectrometer [13]. It works by selecting a thin transverse slice of a pulse's spatial profile, before dispersing it in the orthogonal transverse direction. The result is a two-dimensional image with one axis corresponding to wavelength λ , and the other corresponding to position x along a transverse axis across the pulse's spatial profile (see Figure 1.4a). One can then observe the variation of a given wavelength's intensity across the beam's spatial profile, and identify the centroid position x_0 , representing the center of that wavelength's intensity distribution. Repeating this for a discretised set of wavelengths results in a dataset for $x_0(\lambda)$, to which various models can be fit to characterise the spatio-spectral coupling (see Figure 1.4b). Differentiating these fitted models allows for computing the pulse's spatial dispersion ζ .

1.4 Project Objectives

1. Gather requirements to inform the design of the imaging spectrometer.
2. Design the imaging spectrometer, making use of commercially available components that are either already present in the laboratory or can be procured from companies such as Thorlabs.

3. Construct and align the imaging spectrometer.
4. Characterise the imaging spectrometer using spectral calibration lamps.
5. Write a user interface for the imaging spectrometer for data acquisition and analysis.
6. Test the imaging spectrometer on a laser pulse with a known amount of spatial chirp.

1.5 Report Outline

Chapter 2

Optical Design

2.1 Optical Layout

The imaging spectrometer was designed to accommodate a bandwidth of 760–840 nm as specified by the project supervisor, Dr Benjamin Greenwood, based on the expected operating bandwidth of the laser system. The imaging spectrometer design consists of a 4f imaging system with a diffraction grating inserted in the common Fourier plane (see Figures 2.1 and 2.2). The collimating and focussing optics were selected as lenses rather than spherical mirrors. This is because the use of a spherical mirror at a large angle of incidence produces off-axis astigmatism [18]. This can be mitigated by introducing tight-folds in the optical layout, but this is practically challenging due to having to mount components extremely close to each other. A drawback of using lenses is that they are prone to chromatic aberration [18]. This is particularly detrimental as chromatic aberration is a spatio-spectral coupling and can systematically bias measurements towards larger spatial dispersions. Achromatic doublet lenses were used in an attempt to minimise these effects. The focal lengths of the collimating and focussing lenses were chosen to be 150 mm (Thorlabs AC254-150-B-ML) and 100 mm (Edmund Optics #9823) respectively as a middle ground between maximising the accuracy, and maximising the precision of spatial dispersion measurements (see Section 4.3.1).

A transmission grating was chosen over a reflection grating for the sake of avoiding an impractical tight fold in the optical layout. Specifically, a volume phase holographic transmission grating was used because of its low polarisation dependence and low stray light [19], and $\approx 90 - 95\%$ first-order diffraction efficiency at the 14.6° design angle-of-incidence across the 760-840 nm bandwidth [20].

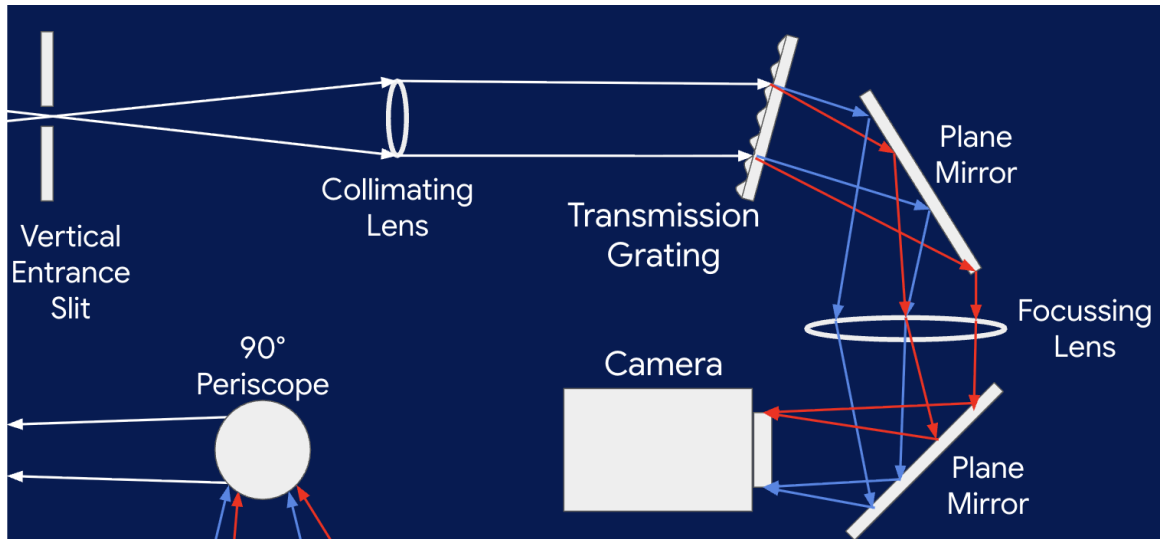


Figure 2.1: Imaging spectrometer schematic from a top view.

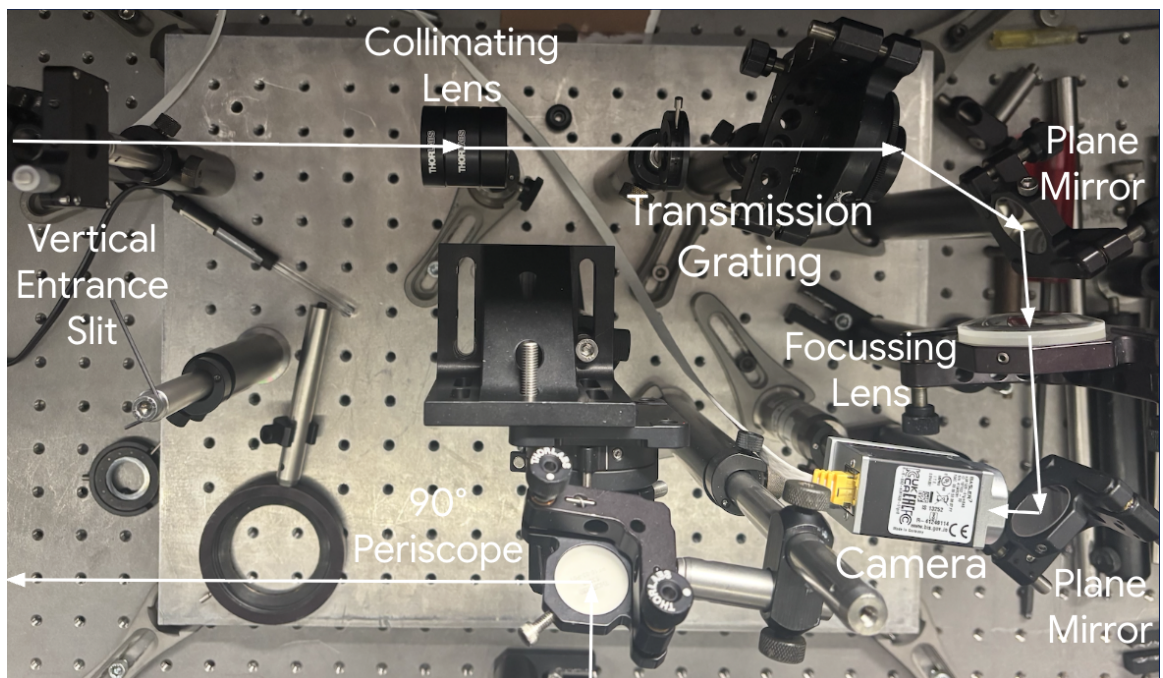


Figure 2.2: Photograph of the imaging spectrometer from a top view.

2.2 Camera and Acquisition Hardware

2.3 Alignment Procedure

2.3.1 Grating-Camera Axis Alignment

2.3.2 Slit-Camera Axis Alignment

Chapter 3

Calibration

3.1 Calibration Architecture

3.2 Sensor Calibration

3.2.1 Baseline

3.2.2 Flat Field

3.2.3 Bad Pixel Map

3.2.4 Conversion Gain

3.3 Spatial Calibration

3.4 Spectral Calibration

3.4.1 Grating Geometry and Predicted Line Spacing

3.4.2 Line Matching

3.4.3 Wavelength Fit and Non-Linear Dispersion

Chapter 4

Analysis Pipeline

4.1 Preprocessing Pipeline

4.2 Noise Model and Uncertainty Propagation

4.3 Spatial Dispersion Fitting

4.3.1 Optical Design Trade-off: Focal-Length Selection

4.4 Multi-Shot Combination

Chapter 5

Graphical User Interface

5.1 Why a GUI

5.2 A Typical Workflow Session

Chapter 6

Experimental Design

- 6.1 Testing with a Known, Controllable Chirp Source
- 6.2 Glass-Induced Spatial Chirp
- 6.3 Predicted Spatial Dispersion
- 6.4 Physical Setup
- 6.5 Measurement Procedure

Chapter 7

Results

7.1 No Glass Window Baseline

7.2 One Glass Window

7.3 Two Glass Windows

7.4 Three Glass Windows

7.5 Summary of Discrepancies

Chapter 8

Discussion

8.1 Taxonomy of Potential Systematic Errors

8.2 Data-Analysis Systematics Considered

8.3 Physical Systematics Considered

8.3.1 Chromatic Aberration and $M(\lambda)$

8.3.2 Residual Camera-Grating Tilt

8.3.3 Scheimpflug-Type Tilt

8.3.4 Other Misalignments and Defects

8.4 Assessment

Chapter 9

Conclusions and Future Work

9.1 Conclusions

9.2 Future Work

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